Fern & Fine Print

INSURANCE EDUCATION, MINUS THE HEADACHE

an Open Enrollment mini-course

The Agent Check

How to work with an insurance agent: what to expect, what no one can promise, how to check a license in any state, and what to do if something feels off.



8 short lessons · printable worksheets · official license lookups for all 50 states + DC

By Suzelaine Similien · Fern & Fine Print · Educational only

What's inside

Read it once. Use it every time someone offers to help.

0	Start Here	4
1	Who's Who, and How They Get Paid	6
2	What to Expect, and What Not to Expect	9
3	Red Flags and Scams	13
4	Verify a License, Step by Step	17
5	The Marketplace Check	23
6	Questions to Ask Any Agent	27
7	If Something Goes Wrong: How to Report It	30

How each lesson works. A short hook, the lesson, key takeaways, the official sources (so you can check every fact yourself), and a one-page worksheet you can print. Pair it with the one-page *Agent Check Checklist*.

About this guide

The Agent Check is written by **Suzelaine Similien**, creator of Fern & Fine Print. Suzelaine is a licensed insurance agent (NPN 16685113). Fern & Fine Print is her separate education business. It does not sell, quote, or recommend insurance, it does not refer anyone to her or to any other agent, and this guide is not an offer of insurance or a solicitation to buy any policy. We share this for transparency.

Educational only. This is general information, not legal, tax, or financial advice, and not advice for your situation. Nothing here guarantees savings, approval, eligibility, or a price. Not affiliated with or endorsed by CMS, HealthCare.gov, NAIC, NIPR, the FTC, any state agency or Marketplace, or any insurance company. Listing an official website isn't an endorsement by it. Links go to outside sites we don't control.

Rules, numbers, and links were checked on official sites on Oct 31, 2026 (ET) and can change. Each lesson lists its sources; the sources are always the final word.

© 2026 Fern & Fine Print · Insurance education, minus the headache. · By Suzelaine Similien

Lesson 0

Start Here

Reading time: about 3 minutes · Worksheet: what I already know, 5 minutes



The hook

It's Open Enrollment. Your phone is buzzing, your feed is full of insurance ads, and someone you've never met wants to "help you get covered today." Some of these people are trained, licensed professionals who do honest work. Some aren't. From the outside they can look exactly the same.

This short course gives you a calm, repeatable way to tell the difference. It takes about 15 minutes to read and about 5 minutes to use, every time.

The lesson

What you'll be able to do by the end

1. Name the four kinds of helpers (agents, brokers, Navigators, and other assisters) and explain how each one gets paid.
2. Know what a legitimate helper **will** do, and what no one can honestly promise you.
3. Spot the most common Open Enrollment scams, including the "free cash card" ads.
4. Check an insurance license yourself, in any state, on the state's own website (all 50 states + DC are in Lesson 4).
5. Confirm whether someone is registered to help with Marketplace plans for 2027.
6. Ask good questions, and know where to report a problem.

What this course is, and what it isn't

- **It is** general education: how the system works, where the official lookups are, and what to ask.
- **It isn't** advice about which plan or which person to choose. We don't recommend, rate, or refer anyone, and we never will. The goal is that *you* can check *anyone*.
- **It's fair to agents.** Most agents and brokers are licensed professionals who follow a long list of rules. Those rules exist to protect you, and the honest professionals in this field generally welcome the questions in this course. A good one won't mind being checked.

How each lesson works

A short hook, the lesson, a worksheet you can print, key takeaways, and the official sources, so you can check every fact yourself. All facts were checked on official sites (CMS, HealthCare.gov, NAIC, NIPR, state insurance departments, and the FTC) on **Oct 31, 2026**. Rules change, so the sources are always the final word.

A note on the two kinds of Marketplace states

For 2027 coverage, **29 states** enroll through HealthCare.gov, and **22 (including DC)** run their own Marketplace website. Some rules in this course, like CMS's agent registration list, apply only to the HealthCare.gov states. Lesson 5 covers both, and the state tables show which kind your state is. If you're unsure, HealthCare.gov's state picker tells you: healthcare.gov/marketplace-in-your-state

Key takeaways

- Legitimate helpers and scammers can look alike. Checking is normal, and it's fast.
- This course teaches you how to check *anyone*. It never tells you whom to pick.
- Facts here were checked Oct 31, 2026. Official sources are always the final word.

Sources

- CMS, EDE Change Request 109 FAQ (Aug 3, 2026): the federal platform serves as the Marketplace in 29 states. cms.gov/marketplace/agents-brokers/files/ede-identity-proofing-agent-broker-authorization-faqs.pdf
- HealthCare.gov, The Marketplace in your state: healthcare.gov/marketplace-in-your-state
- CMS, States by Marketplace Type for Plan Year 2027 (via the Fern & Fine Print state appendix, checked Oct 29, 2026): cms.gov/marketplace/in-person-assisters/training-webinars/training/marketplaces-map

Worksheet · What I already know

1. Right now, someone helping me with insurance is (circle one): an agent · a broker · a Navigator · I'm not sure · no one yet

2. How I first heard from them (circle one): I called them · they called or texted me · an ad · a friend · a website form

3. My state: _____

4. My state enrolls through (circle one): HealthCare.gov · its own Marketplace · I'll check in Lesson 5

5. One thing that's made me nervous this Open Enrollment:

_____

_____

Lesson 1

Who's Who, and How They Get Paid

Reading time: about 4 minutes · Worksheet: name your helper, 5 minutes



The hook

"Agent," "broker," "Navigator," "assister," "enroller," "advisor." During Open Enrollment, everyone seems to have a title, and the titles blur together. They aren't the same job, and they aren't paid the same way. Knowing who's who (and who pays them) is the root of every other check in this course.

The lesson

The four kinds of helpers

Helper	What they do	Licensed or certified by	Recommends plans?	Who pays them
Agent	Helps you apply and enroll; may work for **one** insurance company	Your state (license)	Can make specific recommendations	Usually the insurance company, through a **commission**
Broker	Same work as an agent, but may represent **several** companies	Your state (license)	Can make specific recommendations	Usually the insurance company, through a **commission**
Navigator	Trained, certified helper (often a nonprofit) who helps you apply and enroll	The Marketplace (certification)	No. Required to be unbiased	Not you. **Free to you**
Other assisters (certified application counselors, enrollment assisters)	Trained and certified to help you apply and enroll, including for Medicaid and CHIP	The Marketplace (certification)	No. Must give fair, impartial information	Not you. **Free to you**

HealthCare.gov describes agents and brokers as trained professionals who "must be licensed in their states and have signed agreements to sell Marketplace health plans," who "often get payments ('commissions') from insurance companies for selling plans," and notes that "some may not sell plans of companies they don't represent." Navigators and other assisters "are required to be unbiased," and "their services are free to consumers."

How commissions work, and why it matters to you

On a Marketplace plan, the insurance company generally pays the agent or broker a commission for enrolling you. HealthCare.gov says plainly: **"You won't pay anything additional if you enroll with an agent or broker."** You also still get any premium tax credit and other savings you qualify for, as long as the agent enrolls you *through the Marketplace*.

Why this matters:

1. **You shouldn't be handed a bill for Marketplace help.** In the HealthCare.gov states, if someone asks *you* to pay them to apply or enroll, stop and check (Lesson 3). The FTC lists "you need to pay for help with the Marketplace" as a sign of a scam.
2. **Commissions explain some behavior.** A commission is a normal, legal way to pay for real work. But it also explains why bad actors want to be listed as "your agent" on a policy, even one you never asked for. That's the heart of the unauthorized-enrollment problem in Lesson 3.
3. **An agent may only show some companies.** If an agent is appointed with three insurers, those may be the plans you hear about. That's not wrong. It's just worth knowing, so you can ask (Lesson 6) and compare on HealthCare.gov or your state's Marketplace yourself.

A fair note on fees in some states

Rules differ by state. A few state-run Marketplaces describe brokers who charge a fee. For example, Vermont Health Connect's assister FAQ says brokers there "charge a fee to the customer for their assistance." Where a fee is allowed, states usually require it to be disclosed. **If anyone mentions a fee, ask for it in writing before you agree, and ask your state insurance department if you're unsure** (Lesson 4 lists every department).

Navigators: free, impartial, and sometimes hard to book

Navigators and other assisters are a great option if you want help without anyone recommending a plan. Availability varies a lot by area and by week during Open Enrollment, so book early. You can find assisters through HealthCare.gov's **Find Local Help** tool or your state Marketplace's help page (Lesson 5).

One more helper: the Marketplace itself

The Marketplace Call Center (**1-800-318-2596**, TTY 1-855-889-4325) offers free help 24 hours a day, 7 days a week for HealthCare.gov states. State-run Marketplaces have their own call centers (Lesson 5).

Key takeaways

- **Agents and brokers** are state-licensed, can recommend plans, and are usually paid **commissions by insurers**. On HealthCare.gov, you pay nothing extra for their help.
- **Navigators and other assisters** are certified, impartial, and **free**. They don't recommend specific plans.
- An agent may only offer some companies. Ask which ones.
- If anyone mentions a fee, get it in writing and check with your state insurance department.

Sources

- HealthCare.gov glossary, Agent and broker (health insurance): healthcare.gov/glossary/agent
- HealthCare.gov glossary, Navigator: healthcare.gov/glossary/navigator
- HealthCare.gov, Get help applying (assisters vs. agents/brokers): healthcare.gov/find-assistance
- HealthCare.gov, Protect yourself from Marketplace fraud & scams (assister definition; Call Center hours): healthcare.gov/protect-from-fraud-and-scams
- FTC, Spot Health Insurance Scams (sign #5: paying for Marketplace help): consumer.ftc.gov/articles/spot-health-insurance-scams
- Vermont Health Connect, Assister FAQ (broker fees in Vermont): info.healthconnect.vermont.gov/find-local-help/assister-faq

Worksheet · Name your helper

1. The person helping me calls themselves a(n): _____

2. Based on the table, they're most likely (circle one): agent · broker · Navigator · other assister · not sure yet

3. Did they ask me to pay them anything? ☐ No ☐ Yes → amount and reason:

_____

4. If yes, did they give it to me in writing? ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ N/A

5. Which insurance companies do they say they can offer?

_____

6. My free, impartial backup option (Navigator, assister, or Marketplace call center) and its number:

_____

Lesson 2

What to Expect, and What Not to Expect

Reading time: about 5 minutes · Worksheet: my expectations check, 5 minutes



The hook

A good insurance helper makes a confusing process feel calm. A bad one makes it feel *rushed*. The difference usually shows up in the first five minutes: what they ask for, what they promise, and whether they give you room to think. Here's what normal looks like, so the abnormal stands out.

The lesson

What a legitimate agent or broker WILL do

- **Tell you who they are.** CMS tells agents and brokers to say they are a "state-licensed Marketplace-registered agent or broker selling Marketplace plans," and never to claim they work for CMS, the Marketplace, HealthCare.gov, or an insurer they don't represent.
- **Ask for your consent first, and document it.** Before helping you apply or enroll in a HealthCare.gov-state Marketplace plan, an agent must get your consent and keep a record of it. That record must include, at a minimum:
- the **date** you gave consent,
- **your name** (or your authorized representative's),
- the **name of the agent, broker, or agency** you're giving consent to,
- **what** you're consenting to, **why**, and **for how long**, and
- **how you can take your consent back.**

It can be a recorded call, an email, a text, or a signed form, and you have to take an action to create it (for example, replying or signing). The agent must keep it for at least **10 years**. CMS publishes a model consent form, so you can see what one looks like: cms.gov/files/document/cms-model-consent-form-marketplace-agents-and-brokers.pdf

- **Have you review your application before it's submitted.** The agent must document that you reviewed the information and confirmed it's accurate, and must explain the "attestations" (the statements you agree to) at the end of the application.
- **Use *your* contact information.** CMS says agents must **never** put their own phone number, email, or address on your application, and must never use dummy contact information. You should be the one who gets the Marketplace's texts, emails, and letters.
- **Ask you to approve them electronically (new for 2027 in HealthCare.gov states).** Most agents enroll people through approved "direct enrollment" websites. For Open Enrollment 2027, CMS

requires those sites to get your **authorization** before an agent can act on your application, usually a **one-time passcode or confirmation link** sent to your phone or email that's single-use and expires within **15 minutes**. In some situations (a new application, a new or different agent, or a plan that would cost $30 a month or less after tax credits) you'll also be asked to **verify your identity** first. You'll generally re-authorize your agent **each plan year**.

- **Ask for your Social Security number on the real application.** For agent-assisted HealthCare.gov applications, CMS now requires a Social Security number or immigration document number for every applicant except newborns. That's different from a *quote*: a price estimate shouldn't need your SSN (see "won't" below).
- **Let you think.** You can take a plan summary home, compare it on HealthCare.gov or your state's Marketplace, and decide later in the enrollment window.

What a legitimate helper WON'T do (and what no one can promise)

- **Won't guarantee approval, savings, or a price.** Your eligibility for savings is decided by the Marketplace from your application, and plan prices are set by insurers. CMS specifically tells agents not to guarantee free or low-cost plans to everyone, because not everyone qualifies. A good agent can *estimate*. No one can *promise*.
- **Won't ask for your HealthCare.gov password, or log in as you.** CMS: agents must not log in with a consumer's credentials, must not collect or record your login information, and must not create your HealthCare.gov account for you. That includes screen-sharing or remote-access programs that would let them into your account. **If anyone asks for your password or security code to "get into your account," say no.**
- **Won't ask you to pay them to apply or keep coverage.** You pay your premium **directly to your insurance plan**, not to a person. HealthCare.gov: "The Marketplace, assisters, and your state will never threaten you … or ask for your credit card information or payment to keep or qualify for health coverage."
- **Won't need your SSN, bank, or card number for a quote.** The FTC notes HealthCare.gov needs only basic information like your income and age to show prices.
- **Won't pressure you.** "Today only," "you'll lose your coverage," or "the government says you must" are pressure, not information. Open Enrollment for HealthCare.gov states runs **Nov 1, 2026 – Jan 15, 2027** (enroll by **Dec 15** for coverage starting Jan 1). State-run Marketplaces may have different dates. You have time to check.
- **Won't change your plan without you.** Agents must never change your application or plan selection without documenting your consent to that change.

Your rights in one line

You can **ask questions, take your time, take back your consent, choose a different helper, or do it yourself** on HealthCare.gov or your state's Marketplace.

Key takeaways

- Expect **documented consent**, an **application review**, **your own contact info** on the application, and (in HealthCare.gov states for 2027) an **electronic approval** code or link.
- Never share your **HealthCare.gov password**. Agents aren't allowed to log in as you.
- No one can **guarantee** approval, savings, or a price. Prices come from insurers; eligibility comes from the Marketplace.
- You pay premiums **to the plan**, never to a person. And you're allowed to take your time.

Sources

- CMS, Marketplace Compliance for Agents and Brokers (Aug 28, 2025): consent and application-review documentation elements, 10-year retention, marketing do's and don'ts. cms.gov/files/document/marketplace-compliance-agents-and-brokers.pdf
- CMS, Consumer Consent & Application Review Requirements FAQ (published June 12, 2024): cms.gov/marketplace/agents-brokers/files/frequently-asked-questions-consumer-consent-application-review-requirements.pdf
- CMS, Consumer Consent & Application Review Guide (infographic, updated Oct 30, 2023): cms.gov/marketplace/agents-brokers/files/ab-infographic-payment-notice-2024-requirements.pdf
- CMS, Model Consent Form for Marketplace Agents and Brokers: cms.gov/files/document/cms-model-consent-form-marketplace-agents-and-brokers.pdf
- CMS/HealthCare.gov bulletin, The Do's and Don'ts of Assisting Consumers on HealthCare.gov (Oct 24, 2024): content.govdelivery.com/accounts/USCMSHIM/bulletins/3bcb2db
- CMS, EDE Change Request 109: Identity Proofing and Agent/Broker Authorization FAQ (Aug 3, 2026): cms.gov/marketplace/agents-brokers/files/ede-identity-proofing-agent-broker-authorization-faqs.pdf
- CMS fact sheet, Federal Marketplace Anti-Fraud Actions (Sep 22, 2026): SSN requirement and electronic consumer authorization. cms.gov/newsroom/fact-sheets/federal-marketplace-ffe-sbe-fp-anti-fraud-actions
- HealthCare.gov, Protect yourself from Marketplace fraud & scams (pay premiums to the plan; no payment to qualify): healthcare.gov/protect-from-fraud-and-scams
- HealthCare.gov, Dates and deadlines (Open Enrollment for 2027): healthcare.gov/quick-guide/dates-and-deadlines
- FTC, Spot Health Insurance Scams (quotes and personal information): consumer.ftc.gov/articles/spot-health-insurance-scams
- HealthCare.gov glossary, Premium tax credit: healthcare.gov/glossary/premium-tax-credit

Worksheet · My expectations check

Tick each box when it happens. Any "No" is worth a pause.

What should happen	Yes	No
They told me their name, agency, and that they're licensed	☐	☐
I gave consent in a way I can see (signed, replied, or recorded)	☐	☐
The consent says what it covers, for how long, and how I can take it back	☐	☐
My own phone and email are on my application	☐	☐
I reviewed my application before it was submitted	☐	☐
No one asked for my HealthCare.gov password or to log in as me	☐	☐
No one asked me to pay them	☐	☐
No one promised me approval, a price, or "free" coverage	☐	☐
I felt I had time to think	☐	☐

The one-time code or link I approved came from: _____ on (date): _____

Lesson 3

Red Flags and Scams

Reading time: about 5 minutes · Worksheet: red-flag scan, 5 minutes



The hook

Here's the uncomfortable part. A few years ago, some people discovered they'd been enrolled in a Marketplace plan they never chose, or switched out of the plan they *did* choose, by someone they'd never met. Regulators noticed, and they've been tightening the rules ever since. Knowing what happened is the best way to make sure it doesn't happen to you.

The lesson

What went wrong: unauthorized enrollments and plan switching

Because agents earn a commission from the insurer (Lesson 1), a dishonest agent has a reason to get listed as the agent on as many policies as possible, sometimes without the person's knowledge. CMS calls these:

- **Unauthorized enrollment:** someone enrolls you in a plan without your consent.
- **Unauthorized plan switch:** someone changes your existing plan, or swaps themselves in as your agent, without your consent.

What CMS reported in October 2024 (HealthCare.gov states):

- From **January through August 2024**, CMS received **90,863** complaints of unauthorized plan switches and **183,553** complaints of unauthorized enrollments.
- From **June through October 2024**, CMS **suspended 850** agents' and brokers' Marketplace agreements for reasonable suspicion of fraud or abusive conduct tied to unauthorized enrollments or switches.
- Starting **July 19, 2024**, CMS blocked agents from changing an enrollment unless they were already the agent on it. A new agent then needed a three-way call with you and the Marketplace Call Center (CMS is replacing this step for 2027; see below). CMS reported that plan changes associated with an agent dropped by nearly 70%.

What CMS has done since (Sep 22, 2026 fact sheet):

- On **Aug 31, 2026**, CMS canceled about **315,000 enrollments covering more than 760,000 people** after confirming they were unauthorized.
- Since January 2026, CMS has sent termination notices to **more than 200** non-compliant agents and brokers, and issued **569** notices of intent to terminate.

- CMS paused **new** agent registrations for HealthCare.gov states: agents who didn't have a 2026 agreement can't register for 2027 until **Feb 1, 2027**. This doesn't affect state-run Marketplaces.
- Agents must re-verify their own identity; agent-assisted applications must include verifiable Social Security or immigration document numbers; and, before Open Enrollment, CMS required **electronic consumer authorization** before an agent can act on an application. For 2027, that authorization (a one-time code or link sent to *you*) replaces the old three-way-call step.

The fairness note: these numbers describe the conduct of some agents, not the profession as a whole. CMS says most people who enroll through the HealthCare.gov Marketplace get help from an agent, broker, or web-broker (about 76% of active plan selections in Open Enrollment 2026). Safeguards that stop bad actors also protect the honest agents doing that work.

Red flag 1: the "free cash card" ad

You've probably seen it: *"Claim your $6,400 card for groceries, rent, and gas!"* Here's how the real savings work. The **premium tax credit** lowers your **monthly premium**, and you can take it in advance so your bill is smaller. It is not a debit card, and it isn't cash for groceries. HealthCare.gov warns: **"Be cautious of health insurance ads on social media offering cash, gifts, or other perks. The information you share could be used without your consent."** CMS also tells agents not to mislead people about rewards, gift cards, or discounts for enrolling. The FTC adds that some ads "promise rewards or rebates to anyone who signs up."

Why these ads are risky: many are designed to collect your name, phone number, and details so someone can enroll you or switch your plan, sometimes without you understanding what happened.

Red flag 2: the unexpected call, text, or knock

- HealthCare.gov warns that scammers may **email, text, or come to your home uninvited** and claim to be from the Marketplace.
- The FTC says it's **illegal for companies to robocall you with prerecorded messages marketing health insurance.** If you get one, that's a strong sign of a scammer, or at least someone you may not want to do business with.
- The real Marketplace sometimes calls to confirm application details. HealthCare.gov says those calls come from **1-855-997-1890 or 844-477-7500** (caller ID "Health Insurance MP" or "InsMarketplace"), and the caller gives a first name and ID number. They will never ask for payment. If you're unsure, hang up and call the Marketplace Call Center yourself.

Red flag 3: "I'm from the government"

Agents can't say they represent CMS, the Marketplace, HealthCare.gov, or an insurer they don't actually represent. The FTC's #1 sign of a health insurance scam: someone says they're from the government and needs money or personal information. Government agencies don't call out of the blue asking for your Social Security, bank, or card number, and they don't take gift cards or crypto.

Red flag 4: the "plan" that isn't really insurance

The FTC warns about ads that promise comprehensive coverage but sell **limited-benefit plans** or **medical discount cards**, which aren't health insurance. HealthCare.gov and state Marketplaces are where you're guaranteed comprehensive, ACA-compliant coverage. If you're unsure, ask: "Is this a Marketplace plan?"

Red flag 5: anything that cuts you out of the loop

- Asking for your **HealthCare.gov password** or a **security code** so they can log in as you.
- Putting **their** phone or email on **your** application.
- Telling you to **ignore** texts, letters, or codes from the Marketplace or a plan.
- A **$0 plan** you didn't knowingly choose. (CMS treats very low net premiums, $30 a month or less after tax credits, as one of its "high-risk" signals for extra identity checks.)
- Pressure to decide **today**.

Quick-scan: green flags vs. red flags

Green flag	Red flag
Gives you their name, NPN, and license number without fuss	Won't say, or gets annoyed when you ask
Asks for documented consent; explains what it covers	"Just say yes on the recorded line" without explaining
Your contact info is on your application	Their phone or email is on your application
Talks about estimates and "it depends"	Guarantees $0, approval, or "cash back"
Gives you time; points you to HealthCare.gov to compare	Pressure, threats, "today only"
You pay premiums to the plan	Asks you to pay *them*, or for gift cards

Key takeaways

- Unauthorized enrollments and plan switches were a real, large problem. CMS has suspended or terminated agents, canceled confirmed unauthorized enrollments, and added new safeguards for 2027.
- **"Free cash card" ads** don't describe how premium tax credits work. The credit lowers your premium. It isn't spending money.
- Unexpected robocalls, government impersonation, password requests, and payment demands are **stop signs**.
- Most agents are honest. The point of checking is to make the rare bad actor easy to spot.

Sources

- CMS press release, CMS Update on Actions to Prevent Unauthorized Agent and Broker Marketplace Activity (Oct 17, 2024): cms.gov/newsroom/press-releases/cms-update-actions-prevent-unauthorized-agent-broker-marketplace-activity

- CMS fact sheet, Federal Marketplace (FFE and SBE-FP) Anti-Fraud Actions (Sep 22, 2026): cms.gov/newsroom/fact-sheets/federal-marketplace-ffe-sbe-fp-anti-fraud-actions
- Federal Register, Temporary Moratoria on Certain Agent and Broker Registration To Participate in the Exchanges (interim final rule, effective Sep 22, 2026): federalregister.gov/documents/2026/09/23/2026-19493/patient-protection-and-affordable-care-act-temporary-moratoria-on-certain-agent-and-broker
- CMS, EDE Change Request 109 FAQ (Aug 3, 2026): high-risk criteria, authorization, and the end of the three-way-call block for 2027. cms.gov/marketplace/agents-brokers/files/ede-identity-proofing-agent-broker-authorization-faqs.pdf
- CMS, Marketplace Compliance for Agents and Brokers (Aug 28, 2025): marketing don'ts. cms.gov/files/document/marketplace-compliance-agents-and-brokers.pdf
- HealthCare.gov, Protect yourself from Marketplace fraud & scams: healthcare.gov/protect-from-fraud-and-scams
- HealthCare.gov glossary, Advance premium tax credit: healthcare.gov/glossary/advanced-premium-tax-credit
- FTC consumer alert, "Seeing lots of ads for health insurance plans during open enrollment? Read this" (Oct 29, 2026): consumer.ftc.gov/consumer-alerts/2026/10/seeing-lots-ads-health-insurance-plans-during-open-enrollment-read
- FTC consumer alert, "The low-down on health insurance ads during open season" (Dec 2024): consumer.ftc.gov/consumer-alerts/2024/12/low-down-health-insurance-ads-during-open-season
- FTC, Spot Health Insurance Scams: consumer.ftc.gov/articles/spot-health-insurance-scams

Worksheet · Red-flag scan

Think about the last insurance call, text, ad, or visit you got. Tick any that applied.

- ☐ It came out of the blue (I didn't contact them first)
- ☐ It was a prerecorded robocall
- ☐ It promised cash, a card, gifts, or "free" coverage
- ☐ They said they were from the government or "the Marketplace"
- ☐ They asked for my HealthCare.gov password, a security code, or to screen-share
- ☐ They asked me to pay them, or to pay with a gift card
- ☐ They wanted my SSN or bank info just to give me a price
- ☐ They pressured me to decide today
- ☐ I got a card, letter, or code about a plan I didn't choose

Number of red flags: _____ If it's **one or more**, pause, don't share anything else, and go to Lesson 7.

Who contacted me, and how (name, company, phone, website):

_____

Lesson 4

Verify a License, Step by Step

Reading time: about 5 minutes · Worksheet: my license check, 5–10 minutes



The hook

Every insurance agent and broker in the U.S. must be licensed by the state they're selling in. The good news: every state lets **you** check, for free, on the state's own website. It takes about two minutes, and you don't need anyone's permission. This lesson walks you through it, with the official lookup for all 50 states + DC.

The lesson

First, the three numbers

Number	What it is	Where it comes from
NPN (National Producer Number)	A unique ID for each licensed agent, the same in every state	Assigned through the NAIC's national Producer Database when the agent is licensed
State license number	The agent's license ID in a particular state (some states simply use the NPN)	The state insurance department
Lines of authority	What kinds of insurance they're licensed to sell (for health coverage, look for a health line, often called "Accident & Health" or "Accident and Health or Sickness")	Shown on the state's lookup

An agent who lives in another state can still be licensed in yours. That's called a **non-resident license**. What matters is that they're licensed **in the state where you live and are buying coverage**. CMS reminds Marketplace agents that they must be licensed in each state where they help consumers.

Step by step

Step 1. Ask for the details. Full name (as licensed), NPN, and the state license number for *your* state. A licensed agent can share these easily. (Lesson 6 has the exact wording.)

Step 2. Open your state's official lookup from the table below. Many states share one system run by the NAIC, called **State Based Systems (SBS)**. A handful use a lookup hosted by Sircon, and the rest run their own.

- **SBS states:** go to the SBS Lookup, choose your state as the **Jurisdiction**, choose **Licensee** as the Search Type, choose **Individual**, tick "I agree to the NAIC's Terms and Conditions," and search. Search

by **NPN or license number** if you have it (it's exact), or by **last name plus part of the first name**. Don't fill in every box: if one detail doesn't match exactly, you may get no results. You may see a picture "are you human?" check.

- **Sircon states:** open the consumer inquiry page, choose your state, then search by name or license number.
- **State-run lookups:** follow the on-screen search. Most accept a name, license number, or NPN.

Step 3. Read the result like a pro. Check each of these:

- ☐ **Name and city match** the person you're talking to (names can be shared).
- ☐ **Status is Active.** Other statuses (Inactive, Expired, Terminated, Cancelled) need a closer look. Definitions vary. In New York, for example, "Inactive" means the agent is "currently licensed with no company appointment on file."
- ☐ **A health line of authority** is listed if they're helping with health insurance.
- ☐ **Expiration date** is in the future.
- ☐ **Resident or non-resident** status makes sense (for example, a non-resident license in your state for an out-of-state agent).
- ☐ **Appointments** (the insurance companies they're authorized to represent), if your state shows them. Some do, such as Louisiana's search, which shows current appointments.
- ☐ **Regulatory or disciplinary actions**, if your state shows them. California's lookup, for example, shows discipline history.

Step 4. Can't find them? Don't panic, and don't sign anything yet. Try other spellings, a middle name, or the NPN. You can also try the NAIC's free **Insurance Agent Search**, which asks for first name, last name, city, and state and tells you whether the person is licensed in your state and for which types of insurance: content.naic.org/node/9465. Still nothing? **Call your state insurance department** (website column below) and ask them to confirm.

Step 5. Write it down. Note the date you checked, the status, and the lines of authority on the worksheet. Screenshots are great.

A note on NIPR

NIPR (the National Insurance Producer Registry, an NAIC affiliate) runs the national licensing hub agents use. Its **free NPN lookup** can find an NPN from a state license number: nipr.com/licensing-center/look-up-a-national-producer-number. NIPR's detailed producer reports are for licensees and businesses with a legal "permissible purpose," so **for consumers, the state lookups below are the right tool.**

All 50 states + DC: official agent license lookups

Every link below was opened and checked on Oct 31, 2026 (ET). "SBS" = the NAIC State Based Systems Lookup, which is shared by 31 jurisdictions (pick your state from the Jurisdiction menu). "Sircon" = the Sircon consumer inquiry page that several state insurance departments link to (pick your state from the menu). NAIC has also published a newer address for the SBS Lookup, external-lookup-web.prod.naic.org, which opens the same tool. † = the page loaded but showed an automated "are you human?" check to our link checker, so open it in a normal browser. State websites change; if a link fails, use the department's website or the NAIC directory: content.naic.org/state-insurance-departments

State	Official agent license lookup	How to search	State insurance department
Alabama	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Alabama → Licensee → Individual. State how-to: aldoi.gov/licensing	aldoi.gov
Alaska	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Alaska → Licensee → Individual	insurance.alaska.gov
Arizona	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Arizona → Licensee → Individual. State how-to: difi.az.gov/license-search	difi.az.gov
Arkansas	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Arkansas → Licensee → Individual	insurance.arkansas.gov
California	cdicloud.insurance.ca.gov/cal	CDI Check a License (name or license number). Help page: insurance.ca.gov/license-status	insurance.ca.gov
Colorado	sircon.com/ComplianceExpress/Inquiry/consumerInquiry.do?nonSscrb=Y	Sircon consumer inquiry, choose Colorado (linked by the Division of Insurance). State page: doi.colorado.gov/for-consumers/consumer-protection	doi.colorado.gov
Connecticut	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Connecticut → Licensee → Individual. State how-to: portal.ct.gov/cid/licensing	portal.ct.gov/cid
Delaware	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Delaware → Licensee → Individual. State how-to: insurance.delaware.gov/services/licenseelookup	insurance.delaware.gov
District of Columbia	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = District of Columbia → Licensee → Individual	disb.dc.gov
Florida	licenseesearch.fldfs.com	DFS Licensee Search (name, license number, or NPN). Help page: myfloridacfo.com/division/agents/licensee-search-faq	myfloridacfo.com/division/consumers/contactus
Georgia	ociapp.oci.ga.gov/Agents/AgentStatus.aspx	OCI Agent Status search. Help page: oci.georgia.gov/insurance-resources/agent-individual-agency-company-search	oci.georgia.gov
Hawaii	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Hawaii → Licensee → Individual	cca.hawaii.gov/ins
Idaho	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Idaho → Licensee → Individual	doi.idaho.gov
Illinois	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Illinois → Licensee → Individual. State how-to: idoi.illinois.gov/companies/agent-lookup.html	insurance.illinois.gov
Indiana	sircon.com/ComplianceExpress/Inquiry/consumerInquiry.do?nonSscrb=Y	Sircon consumer inquiry, choose Indiana (IDOI's "Verify Agent/Agency License" link). State page: in.gov/idoi/licensing	in.gov/idoi
Iowa	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Iowa → Licensee → Individual	iid.iowa.gov
Kansas	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Kansas → Licensee → Individual	insurance.kansas.gov
Kentucky	insurance.ky.gov/ppc/Agent/Default.aspx	DOI "Search for a KY Licensee"	insurance.ky.gov
Louisiana	ldi.la.gov/onlineservices/producersearch	LDI Producer/Adjuster Search (shows appointments). Help page: ldi.la.gov/industry/producer-adjuster/search-for-producers-and-adjusters	ldi.la.gov
Maine	maine.gov/pfr/insurance/licensee-search	Bureau of Insurance Licensee Search	maine.gov/pfr/insurance/home
Maryland	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Maryland → Licensee → Individual	insurance.maryland.gov

State	Official agent license lookup	How to search	State insurance department
Massachusetts	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Massachusetts → Licensee → Individual	mass.gov/orgs/division-of-insurance
Michigan	difs.state.mi.us/locators †	DIFS Locator (Insurance tab, Resident or Non-Resident Producer). Help page: michigan.gov/difs/difs-locator-faq	michigan.gov/difs
Minnesota	sircon.com/ComplianceExpress/Inquiry/consumerInquiry.do?nonSscrb=Y	Sircon consumer inquiry, choose Minnesota (linked from Commerce's license lookup page). State page: mn.gov/commerce/licensing/license-lookup	mn.gov/commerce
Mississippi	apps.mid.ms.gov/licensing-search/individual-entity-search.aspx	MID Individual and Entity Licensing Search. Help page: mid.ms.gov/mississippi-insurance-department/licensing-search/individual-and-entity-licensing-search	mid.ms.gov
Missouri	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Missouri → Licensee → Individual	dci.mo.gov
Montana	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Montana → Licensee → Individual	csimt.gov
Nebraska	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Nebraska → Licensee → Individual	doi.nebraska.gov
Nevada	di.nv.gov/nv/r/doi/licensing/search	Division of Insurance "Verify a License". Help page: doi.nv.gov	doi.nv.gov
New Hampshire	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = New Hampshire → Licensee → Individual	nh.gov/insurance
New Jersey	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = New Jersey → Licensee → Individual	state.nj.us/dobi/index.html
New Mexico	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = New Mexico → Licensee → Individual	osi.state.nm.us
New York	myportal.dfs.ny.gov/nylinxext/elsearch.alice?type=Search	DFS Producer Search (name, NY license number, or NPN). Help page: myportal.dfs.ny.gov/nylinxext/psSearchHelp.alice?helpCode=PROSEARCHHELP	dfs.ny.gov †
North Carolina	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = North Carolina → Licensee → Individual	ncdoi.gov
North Dakota	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = North Dakota → Licensee → Individual	insurance.nd.gov
Ohio	gateway.insurance.ohio.gov/UI/ODI.Agent.Public.UI/AgentSearch.mvc/DisplaySearch	ODI Agent/Agency Locator. Help page: insurance.ohio.gov/agents-and-agencies	insurance.ohio.gov
Oklahoma	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Oklahoma → Licensee → Individual	ok.gov/oid
Oregon	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Oregon → Licensee → Individual	dfr.oregon.gov
Pennsylvania	sircon.com/ComplianceExpress/Inquiry/consumerInquiry.do?nonSscrb=Y	Sircon consumer inquiry, choose Pennsylvania (linked from the Department's agent research page). State page: pa.gov/agencies/insurance/consumer-help-center/insurance-company-and-agent-research	insurance.pa.gov
Rhode Island	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Rhode Island → Licensee → Individual	dbr.ri.gov/insurance-overview
South Carolina	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = South Carolina → Licensee → Individual	doi.sc.gov
South Dakota	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = South Dakota → Licensee → Individual	dlr.sd.gov/insurance
Tennessee	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Tennessee → Licensee → Individual	tn.gov/commerce/insurance.html
Texas	sircon.com/ComplianceExpress/Inquiry/consumerInquiry.do?nonSscrb=Y	Sircon consumer inquiry, choose Texas (TDI's "Look up an agent" link). State page: tdi.texas.gov/agent/agent-lookup.html	tdi.texas.gov
Utah	licenseesearch.uid.utah.gov/s/agent	UID Licensee Search. Help page: insurance.utah.gov/licensee-search	insurance.utah.gov
Vermont	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Vermont → Licensee → Individual	dfr.vermont.gov
Virginia	scc.virginia.gov/boi/consumerinquiry/search.aspx?searchType=agent	SCC Bureau of Insurance Agent Search (license number or NPN)	scc.virginia.gov
Washington	insurance.wa.gov/agent-and-company-lookup-tool	OIC Agent and Company Lookup	insurance.wa.gov

State	Official agent license lookup	How to search	State insurance department
West Virginia	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = West Virginia → Licensee → Individual	wvinsurance.gov
Wisconsin	sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup	SBS: Jurisdiction = Wisconsin → Licensee → Individual	oci.wi.gov
Wyoming	sircon.com/ComplianceExpress/Inquiry/consumerInquiry.do?nonSscrb=Y	Sircon consumer inquiry, choose Wyoming (listed in its state menu; Wyoming's licensing portal also runs on Sircon). Questions: the DOI's licensing section. State page: doi.wyo.gov/licensing	doi.wyo.gov

Key takeaways

- Every state lets you check an agent's license for free. Use **your** state's official lookup (table above).
- Search by **NPN or license number** when you can. It's exact.
- Look for **Active**, a **health line of authority**, a future **expiration date**, and a **name and city** that match.
- Can't find them? Try the NAIC Insurance Agent Search or call your state insurance department **before** you share anything else.

Sources

- NAIC, Insurance Agent/Broker Search (free consumer search; state lookup list): content.naic.org/node/9465
- NAIC, Insurance Departments directory: content.naic.org/state-insurance-departments
- NAIC State Based Systems, State Services (list of jurisdictions offering SBS "Lookup – One Search," checked Oct 31, 2026): sbs.naic.org/solar-web/pages/public/stateServices.jsf?state=AR
- NAIC State Based Systems Lookup: sbs.naic.org/solar-external-lookup and external-lookup-web.prod.naic.org
- Arizona DIFI, Finding a License Record (how SBS searches work, including "don't fill in every field"): insurance.az.gov/sites/default/files/documents/files/FindingALicenseRecord.pdf
- Illinois Department of Insurance, Agent Lookup (SBS step-by-step; check status Active and line of authority): idoi.illinois.gov/companies/agent-lookup.html
- New York DFS, Producer Search help and glossary ("Inactive" meaning): myportal.dfs.ny.gov/nylinxext/psSearchHelp.alice?helpCode=PROSEARCHHELP
- California Department of Insurance, Check License Status (status and discipline history): insurance.ca.gov/license-status
- Louisiana Department of Insurance, Producer/Adjuster Search: ldi.la.gov/onlineservices/producersearch
- NIPR, Look up a National Producer Number: nipr.com/licensing-center/look-up-a-national-producer-number
- NIPR, Verify existing licenses (producer reports limited to licensees and permissible-purpose users): nipr.com/licensing/verify-existing-licenses
- CMS/HealthCare.gov bulletin, The Do's and Don'ts of Assisting Consumers on HealthCare.gov (agents must be licensed in each state where they assist): content.govdelivery.com/accounts/USCMSHIM/bulletins/3bcb2db
- Each state's lookup and insurance department website, as listed in the table (all opened Oct 31, 2026).

Worksheet · My license check

Agent's full name: _____ **Agency:** _____

What I checked	What I found
NPN	
License number in my state	
Lookup I used (state + website)	
Status (Active / other)	
Health line of authority listed?	☐ Yes ☐ No
Resident or non-resident in my state	
Expiration date	
Appointments shown (if my state lists them)	
Any actions or discipline shown	☐ None ☐ Yes
Date I checked	

Did everything match what they told me? ☐ Yes ☐ No → what didn't:

_____

Lesson 5

The Marketplace Check

Reading time: about 4 minutes · Worksheet: my Marketplace check, 5 minutes



The hook

A state license lets someone sell insurance. To help you with a **Marketplace** plan (the kind with premium tax credits), an agent needs one more thing: they must be registered and trained with the Marketplace for the current year. For HealthCare.gov states, CMS publishes that list. Here's how to read it, plus where to look if your state runs its own Marketplace.

The lesson

Step 0: Which kind of state am I in?

For 2027 coverage, **29 states** enroll through HealthCare.gov (that includes Arkansas and Oklahoma, which run "state-based Marketplaces on the federal platform"), and **22 (including DC)** run their own Marketplace website. Check yours: healthcare.gov/marketplace-in-your-state

If your state uses HealthCare.gov: two official checks

Check 1. The CMS Agent and Broker Registration Completion List. CMS publishes this list (updated regularly) so the public can "confirm that an agent or broker has successfully completed registration requirements" for the HealthCare.gov Marketplace.

1. Go to data.healthcare.gov/ab-registration-completion-list
2. In **Search NPN**, type the agent's NPN (numbers only). In **Search Plan Year**, type **2027**. Click **Update table**.
3. Read the row: - **Individual Market Registration Completion Date** and **End Date**: there should be a completion date for plan year 2027. (Agent agreements run by plan year and expire, so an old year doesn't count.) - **NPN Valid (Current Plan Year Only)**: CMS checks the NPN against NIPR's licensing records. A **"Y"** means a valid NPN and an **active license with a health-related line of authority**.
4. No 2027 row? It may be a timing issue (CMS says new registrations can take one to two business days to appear), or they may not be registered. Ask them, and don't let anyone act on your application until it shows up.

Good to know for 2027: under a temporary CMS moratorium (effective Sep 22, 2026), agents who did **not** have a 2026 Marketplace agreement can't register for 2027 in HealthCare.gov states until **Feb 1, 2027**. So someone brand new to the Marketplace this fall generally can't be on the 2027 list yet. This doesn't apply to state-run Marketplaces.

Also worth a look: the CMS Registration Termination List. CMS also publishes a list of agents whose Marketplace registration has been terminated or suspended: data.healthcare.gov/ab-suspension-and-termination-list (overview of both lists: data.healthcare.gov/ffm_ab_registration_lists).

Check 2. HealthCare.gov Find Local Help. HealthCare.gov's directory lists Marketplace-registered agents and brokers (and free assisters) who have chosen to be listed: healthcare.gov/find-local-help (choose the "Agents & Brokers" tab in results). Listing is **optional** for agents, and new registrations can take a few business days to appear, so **not** being listed isn't proof of a problem. The Registration Completion List is the more complete check.

If your state runs its own Marketplace

State-run Marketplaces train and certify (or register) the agents and brokers who enroll people through them, and most publish a searchable directory of certified brokers and free assisters. CMS's list doesn't cover these states. Use the table below, and if the person isn't listed, **call the Marketplace** and ask whether they're certified.

All links below were opened Oct 31, 2026 (ET). † = loaded but showed an automated "are you human?" check or scheduled-maintenance page to our link checker; open it in a normal browser, or start from the Marketplace's home page.

State	2027 Marketplace	Official help directory (certified brokers and/or free assisters)
California	Covered California	coveredca.com/get-help/find-an-enroller
Colorado	Connect for Health Colorado	prd.connectforhealthco.com/broker-portal/find-broker
Connecticut	Access Health CT	accesshealthct.com/AHCT/official/astSrch/assistSearch
District of Columbia	DC Health Link	dchealthlink.com/find-expert †
Georgia	Georgia Access	enroll.georgiaaccess.gov/hix/broker/search
Idaho	Your Health Idaho	prd.yourhealthidaho.app/broker-portal/find-expert-help?lang=en
Illinois	Get Covered Illinois	getcovered.illinois.gov/get-help/free-local-help.html
Kentucky	kynect	kynect.ky.gov/benefits/s/auth-reps-assisters
Maine	CoverME.gov	coverme.gov/support/find-help/find-help-near-you
Maryland	Maryland Health Connection	marylandhealthconnection.gov/find-help
Massachusetts	Massachusetts Health Connector	mahealthconnector.org/help-center/in-person-help
Minnesota	MNsure	mnsure.org/help/find-assister †
Nevada	Nevada Health Link	enroll.nevadahealthlink.com/hix/broker/search?anonymousFlag=Y
New Jersey	Get Covered NJ	nj.gov/getcoverednj/help/local

State	2027 Marketplace	Official help directory (certified brokers and/or free assisters)
New Mexico	beWellnm	bewellnm.com/help/free-help
New York	NY State of Health	nystateofhealth.ny.gov/agent/hx_brokerSearch
Oregon	Oregon (new state platform for 2027)	healthcare.oregon.gov/explorehealth/Pages/help.aspx
Pennsylvania	Pennie	pennie.com/find-local-help
Rhode Island	HealthSource RI	healthsourceri.com/enrollment-support
Vermont	Vermont Health Connect	info.healthconnect.vermont.gov/find-local-help
Virginia	Virginia's Insurance Marketplace	enroll.marketplace.virginia.gov/hix/broker/search/individual
Washington	Washington Healthplanfinder	wahealthplanfinder.org †

Arkansas and Oklahoma run state-based Marketplaces on the federal platform, so you enroll through HealthCare.gov and the **CMS checks above apply.**

What these checks do and don't tell you

- **Do:** they tell you the person completed the Marketplace's registration or certification for the year.
- **Don't:** they don't rate anyone, and they don't mean the Marketplace recommends that person. A listing is a starting point. Lessons 4 and 6 still apply.

Key takeaways

- A license (Lesson 4) **plus** Marketplace registration or certification is what lets an agent help with Marketplace plans.
- **HealthCare.gov states:** search the agent's NPN and **plan year 2027** on the CMS Registration Completion List and look for **NPN Valid = Y**. Check the Termination List, too.
- Find Local Help listing is optional, so absence alone isn't a red flag.
- **State-run Marketplaces:** use the Marketplace's own directory, or call and ask.

Sources

- Data.HealthCare.gov, AB Registration Completion List (data last updated Oct 30, 2026): data.healthcare.gov/ab-registration-completion-list
- Data.HealthCare.gov, FFM Agent Broker Registration and Termination Status Page (purpose of the lists; NPN Validation explained): data.healthcare.gov/ffm_ab_registration_lists
- Data.HealthCare.gov, Agent and Broker FFM Registration Termination List: data.healthcare.gov/ab-suspension-and-termination-list
- CMS, Returning Agents' and Brokers' Guide to Plan Year 2027 Marketplace Registration and Training (Find Local Help display preferences; RCL and Find Local Help timing): cms.gov/files/document/032326-returning-ab-registration-training.pdf

- Federal Register, Temporary Moratoria on Certain Agent and Broker Registration (effective Sep 22, 2026; ends Feb 1, 2027): federalregister.gov/documents/2026/09/23/2026-19493/patient-protection-and-affordable-care-act-temporary-moratoria-on-certain-agent-and-broker
- HealthCare.gov, Find Local Help: healthcare.gov/find-local-help and Get help applying: healthcare.gov/find-assistance
- HealthCare.gov, The Marketplace in your state: healthcare.gov/marketplace-in-your-state
- CMS, EDE Change Request 109 FAQ (Aug 3, 2026; federal platform serves 29 states): cms.gov/marketplace/agents-brokers/files/ede-identity-proofing-agent-broker-authorization-faqs.pdf
- Each state-run Marketplace's help page, as listed in the table (opened Oct 31, 2026).

Worksheet · My Marketplace check

My state enrolls through: ☐ HealthCare.gov ☐ Its own Marketplace: _____

If HealthCare.gov:

Check	Result
NPN searched on the Registration Completion List	
Plan year 2027 completion date shown?	☐ Yes ☐ No
NPN Valid = Y?	☐ Yes ☐ No
Searched the Termination List?	☐ Not listed ☐ Listed
Listed on Find Local Help? (optional)	☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Didn't check
Date checked	

If my state runs its own Marketplace:

Check	Result
Found in the Marketplace's directory?	☐ Yes ☐ No
Called the Marketplace to confirm?	☐ Yes ☐ No
Date checked	

Lesson 6

Questions to Ask Any Agent

Reading time: about 4 minutes · Worksheet: my agent question sheet, 10 minutes

The hook

You don't need to be an insurance expert to ask expert questions. You just need the right list, and permission to use it. Here's your permission: licensed professionals are asked these questions all the time, and a good one will answer calmly. Bring this page to the call.

The lesson

The ten questions

About who they are

1. **"What's your full name, your NPN, and your license number in [my state]?"** You'll use these in Lesson 4. (In some states the license number *is* the NPN.)
2. **"Which states are you licensed in, and is your [my state] license resident or non-resident?"** Either is fine. It just needs to be active in *your* state.
3. **"Are you registered with the Marketplace for 2027?"** In HealthCare.gov states, you can confirm on the CMS list (Lesson 5). In states with their own Marketplace, ask whether they're certified with it.

About what they can offer

1. **"Which insurance companies are you appointed with for Marketplace plans in my area?"** An agent may only offer plans from companies they represent. Knowing which ones helps you compare the rest yourself on HealthCare.gov or your state's Marketplace.
2. **"Are you showing me every plan available to me, or only some?"** A fair answer might be "only these companies." That's honest and useful.

About money

1. **"How are you paid for helping me?"** On HealthCare.gov plans, agents are usually paid a commission by the insurance company, and you pay nothing extra. **"Will I be charged any fee?"** If the answer is yes, ask for it **in writing** first and check with your state insurance department.
2. **"Who do I pay my premium to?"** The answer should be: the insurance plan, directly.

About your information and consent

1. **"What consent will you ask me to give, and can I see it first?"** In HealthCare.gov states, the consent record must show the date, your name, the agent's or agency's name, what you're agreeing to, why,

for how long, and how to take it back. **"Who else in your agency will see my information?"** (CMS's model form lets agencies spell this out.)

2. **"Whose phone number and email will be on my application?"** The answer should be **yours**. You'll also want to know: "Will I get a code or link to approve you?" (In HealthCare.gov states for 2027, you generally will. Approve only the agent you chose.)
3. **"Will I review the whole application before you submit it, and will you send me a copy?"** You must confirm it's accurate, and the agent must explain the attestations at the end.

Bonus, for later in the year: "How do I reach you if I get a letter from the Marketplace, or my income changes?"

How to listen to the answers

- **Clear and unbothered** = a good sign.
- **"Don't worry about that," "It's standard, just say yes," or irritation** = slow down.
- **Refusing to give an NPN or license number** = stop. There's no good reason for a licensed agent to withhold it.

What NOT to ask (because no one can honestly answer it)

- "Can you guarantee I'll be approved?"
- "Can you promise my plan will be $0?"
- "Can you lock in this price before I apply?"

Eligibility is decided by the Marketplace, and prices are set by insurers. Anyone who says "yes, guaranteed" to these has told you something important about themselves.

Key takeaways

- Ask for the **NPN and license number** first. Everything else builds on them.
- Ask **how they're paid**, which **companies** they represent, and get any **fee in writing**.
- Ask to **see the consent** and to **review the application**, and make sure **your** contact info is on it.
- Calm, clear answers are a good sign. Refusing to share an NPN is a stop sign.

Sources

- HealthCare.gov glossary, Agent and broker (commissions; "you won't pay anything additional"; some sell only certain companies): healthcare.gov/glossary/agent
- CMS, Marketplace Compliance for Agents and Brokers (Aug 28, 2025): consent and application-review documentation; agents describe themselves as state-licensed and Marketplace-registered. cms.gov/files/document/marketplace-compliance-agents-and-brokers.pdf
- CMS, Model Consent Form (agency disclosure of who can view and use PII): cms.gov/files/document/cms-model-consent-form-marketplace-agents-and-brokers.pdf
- CMS, EDE Change Request 109 FAQ (Aug 3, 2026): consumer contact information and agent authorization. cms.gov/marketplace/agents-brokers/files/ede-identity-proofing-agent-broker-authorization-faqs.pdf

- CMS, Consumer Consent & Application Review Requirements FAQ (attestations): cms.gov/marketplace/agents-brokers/files/frequently-asked-questions-consumer-consent-application-review-requirements.pdf
- HealthCare.gov, Protect yourself from Marketplace fraud & scams (pay premiums to the plan): healthcare.gov/protect-from-fraud-and-scams

Worksheet · My agent question sheet

Date and time of call: _____ **Agent name:** _____

#	Question	Their answer
1	NPN / license number in my state	
2	States licensed; resident or non-resident here	
3	Registered/certified with the Marketplace for 2027?	
4	Insurance companies they're appointed with	
5	Showing all plans, or only some?	
6	How they're paid; any fee to me? (in writing?)	
7	Who I pay my premium to	
8	Consent: what it covers, how long, how to cancel	
9	Whose contact info goes on my application	
10	Will I review it before submission? Copy sent?	

How did the conversation feel? ☐ Calm and clear ☐ Rushed ☐ Pushy

Lesson 7

If Something Goes Wrong: How to Report It

Reading time: about 4 minutes · Worksheet: my report log, 10 minutes

The hook

Maybe you got a card for a plan you never picked. Maybe someone pushed too hard, or wouldn't give you a license number. Reporting it isn't "making a fuss." It's how regulators find patterns, and it's often how your own coverage gets fixed. Here's who handles what.

The lesson

Who to contact, by problem

What happened	Who to contact first	How
Enrolled in a Marketplace plan you didn't choose, or your plan or agent was changed without your OK (**HealthCare.gov states**)	**Marketplace Call Center**	**1-800-318-2596** (TTY 1-855-889-4325), 24/7
Same problem in a **state-run Marketplace** state	**Your state's Marketplace** call center	See its website (Lesson 5 table)
An agent's conduct: pressure, misleading statements, unlicensed selling, a fee you didn't agree to	**Your state insurance department**	Website in the Lesson 4 table, or the NAIC map: content.naic.org/state-insurance-departments
Scam ads, fake "cash card" offers, government impostors, or prerecorded robocalls	**Federal Trade Commission**	reportfraud.ftc.gov
You think your identity or personal information was stolen	**FTC identity theft site**, plus the Marketplace Call Center	identitytheft.gov
Someone claiming to be from the government asked for money or personal info	**FTC**, the **Marketplace Call Center**, and your **local police**	HealthCare.gov recommends all three

CMS says people who believe they may be victims of unauthorized agent activity should call the Marketplace Call Center **"to resolve any coverage issues promptly."** In October 2024, CMS said it was resolving unauthorized plan-switch cases within about 16 calendar days and unauthorized-enrollment cases within about 52 days of receipt.

Before you call: gather your notes

HealthCare.gov suggests keeping a record of anyone who contacts you: **name, who they work for, phone number, street and mailing address, email, and website.** Add:

- **Dates and times** of each contact, and what was said.
- **Screenshots** of ads, texts, or emails (including the ad's page name and link).
- Any **letters, cards, or tax forms** about coverage you didn't choose.
- Your **Marketplace application ID**, if you have one.
- The agent's **NPN and license number**, and what you found in Lessons 4 and 5.

On the call

1. Say clearly what happened: "I did not authorize this enrollment," or "My plan was changed without my consent."
2. Ask for a **case or reference number**, and write it down.
3. Ask what happens next and how you'll be notified.
4. If an agent was involved, consider also filing with your **state insurance department**. That's the agency that licenses them.

Taking back your consent

Your consent record must explain **how to take your consent back** (Lesson 2). If you no longer want an agent acting for you, use that process, keep a copy, and tell the Marketplace when you call.

A fair reminder

Most complaints get sorted out, and most agents never get one. If your concern turns out to be a misunderstanding, that's a good outcome too. You checked, and that's the whole point.

Key takeaways

- **Unauthorized enrollment or plan change (HealthCare.gov states):** Marketplace Call Center, **1-800-318-2596**. State-run Marketplace states: call your Marketplace.
- **Agent conduct or licensing:** your **state insurance department**.
- **Scam ads, impostors, robocalls: ReportFraud.ftc.gov**. Identity theft: **IdentityTheft.gov**.
- Keep notes, screenshots, and every **case number**.

Sources

- CMS press release, CMS Update on Actions to Prevent Unauthorized Agent and Broker Marketplace Activity (Oct 17, 2024): Call Center guidance and resolution times. cms.gov/newsroom/press-releases/cms-update-actions-prevent-unauthorized-agent-broker-marketplace-activity
- HealthCare.gov, Protect yourself from Marketplace fraud & scams (what to record; report to the FTC, local police, and the Call Center): healthcare.gov/protect-from-fraud-and-scams

- FTC, ReportFraud.ftc.gov: reportfraud.ftc.gov
- FTC, IdentityTheft.gov: identitytheft.gov
- FTC consumer alert (Oct 29, 2026): report misleading ads and illegal robocalls at ReportFraud.ftc.gov. consumer.ftc.gov/consumer-alerts/2026/10/seeing-lots-ads-health-insurance-plans-during-open-enrollment-read
- NAIC, Insurance Departments directory: content.naic.org/state-insurance-departments
- CMS, Marketplace Compliance for Agents and Brokers (consent must include how to rescind): cms.gov/files/document/marketplace-compliance-agents-and-brokers.pdf

Worksheet · My report log

Date	Who I contacted	Phone/website	Case or reference #	What they said / next step

What happened, in two sentences:

_____

_____

Who contacted me (name, company, phone, email, website):

_____

Evidence I saved: ☐ Screenshots ☐ Texts/emails ☐ Letters/cards ☐ Call log ☐ Consent form copy